

OZVOR WHITEPAPER • GET-CITED KIT, PART 2

Understanding GEO Search

How AI answer engines decide which businesses to name
— and what that means for yours

Ozvor

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How AI search engines choose who to recommend — and what to do about it

An Ozvor guide · The Get-Cited Kit, Part 2

What you'll get from this guide: by the last page, you'll understand exactly how ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews decide which businesses to name — and you'll have already run one real test on your own business to see where you stand.

Try this now (2 minutes)

Open ChatGPT, Gemini, or Perplexity and ask the exact question a customer would ask: *"best [your category] in [your city]"* or *"[your category] for [a specific situation]"*. Write down what it says. Does it name you? Does it name a competitor? Is what it says about you even accurate?

Most business owners have never done this. It's the fastest way to understand everything below — because the rest of this guide explains *why* the AI answered the way it did, and what you can do to change the answer.

Want the full picture, not just one prompt? The free AI Visibility Test runs this exercise for you automatically — across five AI engines, benchmarked against up to three competitors, in about two minutes, no credit card required. Start at ozvor.com/test.

Who this is for. You run a real business. You're not a marketer, and until recently the most you thought about search was making sure your Google listing had the right phone number. This is written for you, in plain English, with real numbers and named sources.

In this guide

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1. Why this is already costing you customers

For twenty years, getting found online meant ranking on Google's page of ten blue links. Now, AI answer engines — ChatGPT, Google's AI Overviews, Gemini, Perplexity, and Claude — read the web for the customer and hand back a short, finished answer that names **two or three businesses**. There is no page two. You're either named, or you don't exist in that conversation.

That's what makes this dangerous: it's invisible. You can keep your Google rankings exactly where they are and still lose customers, because the AI answered the question before the customer ever reached a page to rank on. There's no dashboard for a conversation that happened inside ChatGPT and ended without your name in it.

The scale is not a forecast — it has already happened:

What changed	The number	Source
ChatGPT's weekly users	~900M (Feb 2026), more than double a year earlier	OpenAI, via TechCrunch
Google AI Overviews' reach	2B+ people/month, 200+ countries	Alphabet Q2 2025 earnings
Buyers who start research in AI	37-44%	Eight Oh Two, 2025 / Bain, 2026
US Google searches ending in zero clicks	~68%, up from ~60% in 2024	SparkToro, Jun 2026
Click rate on a normal result when an AI summary appears	8%, vs. 15% without one	Pew Research Center, Jul 2025
Brands that track their AI-search visibility at all	~16%	HubSpot, 2025

Do this: if you haven't already, run the 2-minute test above on your top three buyer-intent questions before reading further — the rest of this guide will make a lot more sense once you've seen your own result.

2. How AI engines actually decide who to cite

The good news: this isn't a black box or a popularity contest. It's been studied.

Two ways your business ends up in an answer:

- **Training data (slow).** Baked in when the model is built. Anything you publish today won't reach a model's built-in memory until its next training run — often months away.
- **Live retrieval (fast).** ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Google AI Mode, and Claude can all fetch and cite live web pages while answering. Content you publish this month can be cited within days or weeks. (ChatGPT runs a live search on an estimated 34.5% of queries — Siana Marketing, 2026 — so you're playing for both lanes.)

Either way, AI matches your content to the question **by meaning, not keyword**. "Invisalign consultation in the city centre" gets matched. "We love helping clients smile" does not.

What actually moves the needle: a peer-reviewed study from Princeton, Georgia Tech, the Allen Institute for AI, and IIT Delhi (KDD 2024, arXiv:2311.09735) tested nine content tactics against 10,000 real queries:

Tactic	Lift in AI visibility
Add quotations from credible sources	+41%
Add concrete statistics	+33%
Cite authoritative sources inline	+28% avg (up to +115% for a page starting in 5th place)
Combine fluency + statistics	+5.5% over the best single tactic
Keyword stuffing	-8.7% (the only tactic that backfired)

Do this: every piece of content you publish should include at least one real number and one named, credible source. That's the core formula — and it favors the clearest answer, not the biggest budget.

3. Where AI actually looks for citations

The most-cited sources, in order: Reddit, YouTube, LinkedIn, Wikipedia, Forbes (Peec AI, 30M sources, 2026). Reddit alone accounts for ~3.11% of citations across engines; Wikipedia is ~16% of ChatGPT's citations by itself (Ahrefs, 2025).

Sobering detail: about 68% of ChatGPT's top citations point to places a small business can't realistically influence — Wikipedia, brand homepages, app stores. That leaves roughly **1 in 3 citation seats** genuinely winnable: educational content, review sites, news, blogs (Ahrefs, Sep 2025).

The finding that should change how you feel about this: LinkedIn is the #2 most-cited domain (~11% of AI answers, up to 14.3% on ChatGPT Search) — and the median cited LinkedIn post had **just 15-25 reactions and one comment or fewer**. 95% were original content (Semrush, 2026). AI isn't citing viral posts. It's citing specific, credible answers. That's a contest a one-person business can win.

One more thing: the mix changes. In one three-month study, Reddit's share of ChatGPT citations swung from ~60% to ~10% after a single change in how Google surfaced results (Semrush, 2025). This is why GEO is ongoing work, not a one-time fix — and why early movers compound their advantage: across 100 runs of the same prompt, only about 5 of 44 possible brands got named 80%+ of the time (Search Engine Land / Fishkin, Feb 2026).

Do this: publish where the winnable seats are — your own site, LinkedIn, review platforms, industry Q&A — with specific, sourced answers.

4. Why the customers AI sends you convert better

Visibility isn't the goal — customers are. AI doesn't just send traffic; it tends to send *buyers*:

Evidence	Finding	Source
Microsoft Clarity (1,277 sites)	AI visitors sign up at ~11x the rate of search visitors	Microsoft, Nov 2025
Adobe Analytics (1T+ retail visits)	AI-referred traffic converts 42% better, drives 37% more revenue per visit	Adobe, Q1 2026
Forrester (18,000 buyers)	94% of B2B buyers use AI somewhere in their journey	Forrester, Jan 2026
Seer Interactive (5.47M queries)	Brands cited in AI Overviews get 120% more organic clicks	Seer, Apr 2026
G2 (1,076 buyers)	1 in 3 B2B buyers bought from a vendor they discovered through AI	G2, Mar 2026

The honest counterweight: Amsive, studying 54 sites, found no statistically significant overall difference between AI and organic conversion rates (4.87% vs 4.60%, $p=0.794$), though high-traffic sites did see a lift. A couple of widely-quoted multipliers (Visibility Labs, Semrush) are single studies, not consensus — we flag this because a field full of guaranteed-results claims deserves a dose of honesty.

What survives every dataset: AI visitors convert at least as well as search visitors, often better — because by the time someone asks an AI a buying question, the AI has already done the comparison shopping. The visitor who reaches you has effectively been pre-vetted. **But you can't convert a customer the AI never named.**

Do this: treat GEO as a revenue channel, not a vanity metric. If you're not cited, you're not in the running — no matter how good your close rate is once someone does find you.

5. If you're small or local, the math is starker — and so is the opening

SOCi's 2026 Local Visibility Index (~350,000 locations, 2,751 brands) is the key dataset here:

Finding	Number
Local locations ChatGPT recommends, per query	~1.2% (vs. 35.9% in Google's local 3-pack)
Local businesses ChatGPT never mentions at all	98.8%
Difficulty of AI local visibility vs. traditional local search	3-30x harder
Brands ranking top-20 locally <i>and</i> top-20 in AI	Only 45% overlap
Accuracy of AI's business-profile info	~68%

Home services is starker still: an estimated 87% of independent HVAC and plumbing contractors have effectively zero AI citation share, while a handful of national franchises capture roughly 19% of citations in the category (5WPR, Q1 2026). And customers are asking: 45% now use AI for local recommendations, up from 6% a year earlier (BrightLocal, Mar 2026).

The levers you actually control (and most competitors are ignoring):

- **Reviews.** Vendor research suggests 50+ recent reviews correlates with ~3x higher odds of an AI recommendation (GrowthPro/SOCi, directional); AI-recommended locations average 4.3 stars (SOCi, higher-confidence data).
- **Accuracy.** Business-profile data is only ~68% accurate in AI — matching your name, services, hours, and location everywhere is a real edge.
- **Recency.** AI favors fresh content, and reviews are a constant freshness signal you control.

Do this: audit your reviews, business-info accuracy, and posting recency this week — these three levers alone separate the 1.2% who get named from everyone else.

6. GEO doesn't replace SEO — it runs on the same foundation

	SEO	GEO
Goal	Rank among Google's links	Be named inside an AI-generated answer
The win	A clickable link	A mention in the answer text
Leans on	Backlinks, keywords	Structured, specific, quotable, sourced content
Time to impact	Months to years	Weeks, via live retrieval
Failure mode	Page two (visible)	Not named (invisible)

They share the same plumbing:

1. **Crawlability.** If GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, or Google-Extended are blocked, or your pages don't load cleanly, you're invisible to AI the same way you'd be invisible to Google. URL accessibility and search rank are the two strongest citation factors in one synthesis of 54 experiments (Zyppy, 2026).
2. **Structure.** Clean headings and schema.org markup help AI parse and quote your pages — though schema's direct effect on citation is modest and engine-dependent (Otterly.ai, 2026). Good hygiene, not a magic switch.
3. **Freshness.** AI-cited URLs are ~25.7% more recently updated than top organic results (Ahrefs, ~17M citations, Dec 2025). Publishing and updating regularly feeds both systems.

Do this: fix your technical foundations once — crawlers, page speed, schema — and they improve your odds in Google *and* AI at the same time.

7. Your checklist for this week

1. **See where you stand.** Ask ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, and Claude your real buyer-intent questions. Note who's named and whether the details are accurate.
2. **Unblock the crawlers.** Confirm GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, and Google-Extended aren't blocked in robots.txt, and that key pages load fast and clean.
3. **Fix your factual footprint.** Make your name, services, hours, and location identical everywhere. Inconsistent data is a real reason AI gets you wrong.
4. **Claim and feed your review profiles.** Ask happy customers for recent reviews on the platforms your category uses.
5. **Publish specific, sourced content — consistently.** One real statistic, one credible quote, one clear point of view, one question answered completely per piece. Post it on your own site and on LinkedIn.
6. **Re-check on a schedule.** Where AI looks shifts month to month. A one-time fix doesn't stay fixed.

An honest promise. No one can guarantee you'll be cited by name — anyone who says otherwise is selling something. What the research above shows is that certain practices measurably raise your odds, and being absent from the sources AI draws on guarantees you won't be cited. That's the whole game: improve your odds, then keep improving them as the ground shifts.

8. Where this leads

Everything above, a determined owner could do by hand — run the prompts, track who's named, fix the crawlers, publish consistently, and keep it current as the ground shifts. The hard part is *keeping it current*, across five engines, every week. That's the job Ozvor exists to do.

The path: Free AI Visibility Test (ozvor.com/test) → The Get-Cited Kit — \$29 → Growth — \$99/mo (ozvor.com/pricing) → Agency — \$249/mo (ozvor.com/agencies) → OrganicPosts by Ozvor (ozvor.com/organic-posts, done-for-you).

Step	What it is	Price
Free AI Visibility Test — ozvor.com/test	See where you stand across 5 AI engines, benchmarked against up to 3 competitors	Free, no credit card
The Get-Cited Kit	Prioritized fixes ranked by impact, plus 3 ready-to-publish drafts — a blog post, a LinkedIn post, and an FAQ entry with schema	\$29
Growth — ozvor.com/pricing	Weekly monitoring, citation tracking, and ongoing GEO content, up to 10 competitors	\$99/mo
Agency — ozvor.com/agencies	Up to 25 brands, white-label reports, and client workflow	\$249/mo
OrganicPosts by Ozvor — ozvor.com/organicposts	Done-for-you: our team handles the publishing and optimization	Custom

Start free, see exactly where you stand, then decide how much of the ongoing work you want to do yourself versus hand to us.

Run your free AI Visibility Test now: ozvor.com/test — two minutes, five engines, no credit card required. Questions? hello@ozvor.com.

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A note on the figures. Platform user counts are self-reported by the companies; survey figures carry the usual sampling caveats and are attributed by source above. Single-vendor conversion multipliers are flagged as directional, and contested findings are presented alongside their counter-evidence. AI behavior is non-deterministic — the same prompt can yield different answers on different days and engines. We cite the contrarian data on purpose: the case for GEO doesn't need overstatement to stand up.